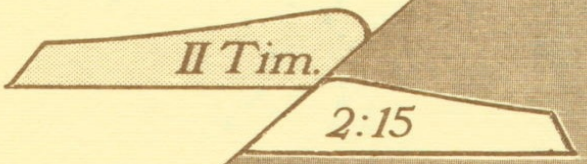
Concise Thoughts on Grace Truth



by Harry Bultema

Concise Thoughts
on
Grace Truth

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Preface by
Daniel C Bultema

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CONCISE THOUGHTS ON GRACE TRUTH

Preface

Pastor Harry Bultema had a long and blessed ministry for 35 years as pastor of the Berean Church in Muskegon, Michigan. In addition to his pastoral ministries, which included 25 years of radio broadcasts of the Sunday Morning messages, he was a prolific writer of Bible study material.

Several books of his writings were published in his lifetime and he left a heritage of many unpublished manuscripts, including commentaries on many books of the Bible, a number of writings on critical Bible subjects as well as a Systematic Theology of perhaps over 500 pages on major Bible doctrines. Through the encouragement of many friends, steps are now being taken to make available many of my father's writings.

In January, 1942, my father began a monthly Bible study magazine called the MORNING STAR. In the foreword of that first issue my father stated, "On the last page of Holy Writ, Christ calls Himself by that lovely name. In Revelation 2:28 He says to the faithful, 'I will give him the MORNING STAR.' Our worthy purpose is to build up the saints by the unfolding of the unsearchable riches of His Word and grace. We know this will be to the praise and glory of His name."

This magazine was used of the Lord to inform and encourage His people until shortly after my father was ushered into the presence of the Lord in September, 1952.

The articles in this pamphlet were first published in the MORNING STAR. The emphasis in this collection of articles is on the special revelation given to the Apostle Paul and on the ministry which our resurrected Lord gave to the Apostle of the Gentiles for this age of grace.

It is our prayer that these CONCISE THOUGHTS ON GRACE TRUTH will be to the praise and glory of our blessed Lord.

Daniel C. Bultema

THE APOSTLE OF THE GENTILES

When Christ was on earth His order was to the Jews only. After He had been in heaven for seven years, the order was still for Peter to the Jews only, since Peter so emphatically says, "It is an unlawful thing for a man that is a Jew to keep company, or come to one of another nation" Acts 10:28. Read the repeated addresses to the men of Israel in Acts 2 and Acts 5:31. Even in Acts 11:19 the Jews of Jerusalem preached to the Jews only. There are plenty of traditions but there is not one Bible proof that one of the twelve ever preached outside the Holy Land. After Saul was separated by the Holy Spirit in Acts 13:2 he became the apostle to the Gentiles, Romans 11:13; 15:16.

During the Acts period Paul behaved as a Jew under the law in order to win the Jews under the law. As a born Jew it was his cultural duty to so act and he did not compromise as so many think. He was no man to compromise. Besides he could not very well have put himself constantly forward as an example to be imitated if he had been a turncoat. Neither could he have said at the end of his life that he had fought a good fight if he had repeatedly temporized. He was always right in Acts as when he took a Jewish vow, shaved his head, Acts 18:18; circumcised Timothy, Acts 16:3; celebrated Pentecost, Acts 20:16; apologized to the wicked Jewish High Priest; sat for seven days as a Jew in the temple; brought bloody offerings, Acts 21:24-29. We should remember that this was all before the great boundary line of Acts 28 and God was still dealing with Israel as His nation.

Paul did not work under Peter with his keys, Matthew 16:19, but contrariwise. Paul was a younger man and Peter was an older man with more experience. However, when Paul stayed at his home as guest for a few weeks, Peter did not add anything to Paul. On the other hand Paul added something to Peter, Galatians 2:6. It is the awful blunder of the historical Church to have followed Peter instead of Paul. This undoubtedly was one of the reasons why the Pauline truth was lost so soon in the Church of Christ. Peter and his fellow-apostles agreed to the arrangement of Galatians 2:9, not with a view to the commission of Mark 16:15, 16, but because they saw in Paul's words the leading of the Holy Spirit for the new day just dawning.

Paul was the most humble of men that ever lived. He called himself less than the least of all saints. Yet this same man used the personal pronoun more often than any other man and put himself forth as an example to be followed more than any other Bible or Church saint has ever done. Wonder why? It was because he was and is the man God has chosen as the Apostle of the Body of Christ to make known the secret which was hid in God and in all ages and generations, but made known to Paul when Israel hardened itself. What a shame that after nearly two thousand years of preaching and teaching this humble instrument of Christ is not better known and appreciated concerning his wonderful message for the Church.

Paul mentions himself in pronouns over 1,000 times. That seems to be egotistic. Still, it is a blessed fact grasped but by few, that men will emphasize in red letters the words of Christ, Who was the minister of the circumcision, whereas they ignore

the heavenly truth our risen and ascended Lord gave to Paul and to us through Paul. Our Lord had many things to say which the disciples could not bear, but He later revealed them from heaven to Paul. They were not the things concerning His kingdom, but rather the things concerning His Body and it's Head. See Ephesians 3:1-10. Ever since Nietzsche ranted against Paul, a veritable revolt has broken out against our Apostle. Weiss, Weinel, and Wernle praise the man but fight his theology. Trotingham calls him self-centered and narrow. According to Schlechter he is vain, overbearing, arrogant, lacking in charity, and a woman-hater. Dr. Jowett describes him as a poor decrepit creature suffering from palsy. Many critics take him for an epileptic. Most critics, however, praise the man in order to slaughter his mandate.

PAUL THE CASTAWAY

"Lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway." I Cor. 9:27.

Paul was afraid that he might be a castaway; set aside, not from salvation, but as a worker from his work and the worker's reward.

He was a castaway from men. Study his life and you will see that he was a castaway everywhere. Where Ananias, Peter, James, John and the others were not persecuted, there he was rejected.

Rejected at Damascus, Acts 9:23-25.

Rejected at Jerusalem, Acts 9:26-29.

Rejected at Antioch in Pisidia, Acts 13:45-50.

Rejected at Iconium, Acts 14:5.

Rejected at Philippi, Acts 16:12-39.

Rejected at Thessalonica, Acts 17:5.

Rejected at Berea, Acts 17:13.

Rejected at Athens, Acts 17:18:32.

Rejected at Ephesus, Acts 19:9-23.

Rejected by all Asia, II Tim. 1:15.

Rejected in Rome, Acts 28:24-29; II Tim. 4:10-16.

The point is, we must sharply discriminate between man's casting away and God's casting away. Paul never feared the former, but he did fear the latter. Saints today often reverse this order.

Why did Paul want to go to Jerusalem even in the face of pleadings for him not to go from fellow-believers? It was not mere love for Israel since he could love Israel outside of Jerusalem. Nor was it merely love for the Jewish poor, for he could have sent them gifts by others. No, he went to Jerusalem in order to be conformed to Christ in every thing.

They shouted "away with him," as they had done with Christ. The legalists persecuted him just as they had done with the Lord. They bound him and delivered him into the hands of the Gentiles. They hated him without a cause and lied about him, just as they had done with his Master. He wanted to be conformable to Christ's death.

To say that Paul made a blunder and compromised in going to Jerusalem is a great error. A temporizer could not say as Paul did so often, "Follow me!"

Here is proof that Paul was right:

1. He was bound in the Spirit. This might refer to the human spirit, but in connection with the whole story, it evidently refers to the Holy Spirit or at least His power.

2. If Paul had been out of line Christ would not have comforted him the way He did in Acts 23:11. Consider how harshly he dealt with Jonah when this prophet was out of the way.

3. In Acts 20 Paul set himself as an example before the Ephesian elders. His conscience would not have allowed him to do this, nor would the Holy Spirit, if he had been a miserable compromiser.

4. He claimed to be "pure from the blood of all men," which would not have been true if he had compromised, for, when Peter compromised in Antioch, he drew many others with him into hypocrisy.

5. He could say, "I finish my course with joy." The man who is out of the will of God cannot say that, for he is wretched and miserable.

6. At the end of life he said, "I have fought a good fight," which again could not be true if he had been so sadly out of God's will.

7. The weakest negative, "me," is used in the Greek word "not" in Acts 21:4. This expresses a relative, subjective and conditional "not." It is not the stronger word "ou."

8. Finally, if Paul had been a man pleaser he would, according to his own statement in Gal. 1:10, not have been a servant of Christ, and the Holy Spirit could not have put him before the Church as the great paragon saint and servant of all ages. There is nothing God hated more than compromise.

BRIEF EXPOSITION OF A MYSTERY

Romans 11:25. "For I would not, brethren, that ye should be ignorant."

Whenever the Apostle says something unusually important, he comes with this warning, as in Romans 1:13; 11:25; I Corinthians 10:1; 12:1; II Corinthians 1:8; I Thessalonians 4:13. In this letter of Romans he particularly emphasizes the need of knowledge, 1:13; 2:4; 6:3; 7:1; 10:3; 11:25. Israel was ignorant of God's righteousness, and now he warns the Gentiles not to fall into the same trap. In Romans 6 he warns four times that believing readers should know their union with Christ.In I Corinthians 6 he exclaims six times, "Know ye not," (1,3,9,15,16,19). Believers ought not be ignorant of spiritual gifts, I Corinthians 12:1. They should not be ignorant of Satan's devices, II Corinthians 2:11. Nor may they be ignorant of those who have fallen asleep, and of the return of Christ for and with His own, I Thessalonians 4:1318. Instead of being an optimistic postmillenarian who believes that this age will culminate in a millennium of religiosity, the Apostle exhorts them, "this know also that in the last days perilous times shall come" I Timothy 3:15.

And so believers should not be ignorant of God's way with Israel, and the particular mystery connected with it. We cannot refrain from stating our amazement that this warning could have been so universally disregarded. For not only are the common people in our so-called Christian society ignorant of God's way with Israel, but the orthodox pulpit and pew as well. They know a little about Israel's past through their Christian training. They know a little of Israel's dispersion and distress in this present age and especially in our present time. However, they do not know that God has said far more about Israel's future than about Israel's present. They do believe that God scattered Israel for their sins, but they do not believe that He in His day will gather and spiritually and territorially restore them in His great mercy and covenantal faithfulness. Yet God has said, "He that scattereth will also gather them." It is not Paul only but God Who says, "I would not that ye should be ignorant, brethren."

Romans 11:25, Mystery.

This word means a sacred secret that God alone knows. Man can never know this divine secret unless God reveals it to him. In the Gospels it is used only three times; the mysteries of the Kingdom, Matthew 13:11; Mark 4:11; Luke 8:10. All in all there are twelve different mysteries revealed in the twenty-eight times this term is used.

The Mystery of the Kingdom in the Gospels.

The mystery of Israel's temporal and partial blindness, waiting for the coming in of the "pleroma," (fullness) as we have it in this passage.

The mystery of the Body of Christ, Ephesians 3:1-10.

The mystery of marriage illustrating the union of Christ and the Church, Ephesians 5:28:32.

The mystery of God and of Christ as the incarnate fullness of the Godhead, Colossians 2:2,3.

The mystery of godliness, or the secret of the wonderful processes by which true godliness is restored to fallen man, I Timothy 3:16.

The mystery of iniquity, II Thessalonians 2:7.

The mystery of faith, I Timothy 3:9.

The rapture of the Church, I Corinthians 15:51.

The mystery of the seven stars, Revelation 1:20.

The mystery of God, Revelation 10:7.

The mystery of Babylon, Revelation 17:8.

Our generation, alas, is more interested in mystery novels and crime mysteries than in these revealed mysteries of God, and the stewards of these mysteries have become very few, I Corinthians 4:1. Among the pagans there were but few initiated into their weird mysteries, but God has disclosed His sacred secrets to all His own in order that they in turn should divulge them to others. The strange mysteries of the heathen could be grasped by but few, but the revealed mysteries in God's Word can be easily comprehended by faith. But why are these secrets so little known among believers? It is because of the paradoxical unbelief of believers. The things of God are not to the taste of carnal folk.

Romans 11:25, "Lest ye should be wise in your own conceits."

Knowledge can cure deceit. Let us enumerate a few of the many conceits that have risen in Christendom as the result of the culpable ignorance regarding this mystery about Israel.

1. The first colossal conceit was, we, the Church, are Israel.

2. Israel had a great temple, hence we must have great cathedrals, and thus the poor were bled white in order to build heaps of stones, while God was not being worshipped in Spirit and truth.

3. Israel had a prescribed ritualism, hence the ritualism of the Church.

4. Israel's nontransferable name was stolen by hundreds of sects.

5. Israel's glory, Romans 9:4, was transferred, resulting in externalism.

6. Israel's feasts were appropriated one by one.

7. Israel's Sabbath was taken, and hence Sabbatarianism.

8. Israel's covenants were taken, hence all the covenant-theologies.

9. Israel's law was split into a civil and moral law, and the latter was transferred, hence all the legalisms with all the concomitant hostility to free grace.

10. Israel had to exterminate the Canaanites and false worshippers, hence all the bloody persecutions.

11. Israel had to exterminate the witch, hence the satanic history of witchcraft-persecutions.

12. Israel had many miracles, the Church none, hence men like D. Hume and the Deists, Rationalists, Encyclopedists easily lapsed into infidelity when they never saw any miracle in the Church. All infidelity rests on this false premise.

13. Israel had great fathers, hence the Church boasted of the so-called Church fathers, who were godly men, but actually Church babies in the truth.

14. Israel had a hope of earthly greatness and primacy, hence the system of Papacy and all it stands for. Romanism is a mixture of Judaism, Christianity, and Paganism.

15. Regarding itself as Israel, there could not be a rightly dividing of the Word and a giving heed to the Word of Prophecy. All the prophetic truth had to be bent into the thought, we are Israel.

16. With Israel filling the vision, the specific truth known as Body truth could not be known. Hence the Church today does not know Israel nor the Church.

Romans 11:25, Blindness in part is happened to Israel.

Blindness is "porosis." In Mark 3:5 this is rendered "hardness." It denotes not a physical but a spiritual blindness, which is the result of the hardening of the heart. This blindness then is said to be partial and temporal. The word " until" clearly intimates that some day it will be ended.

Blindness as a judgment was not something strange to Israel's ears. They knew the story of Sampson's blinding because of his sin. They had read of Zedekiah's blindness. They perhaps knew the story of Bartimeus and Bar-Jesus, and how their blindness was miraculously cured. If the God of Israel who alone doeth wondrous things, could cure the latter two, then He certainly can cure the blindness of a whole nation. Mentally, Israel sees sharply the areas of finance, law, politics, diplomacy, psychology medicine, philosophy and all the liberal arts and sciences. One has only to look around in modern society to be clearly convinced of that. Even morally, Israel sees just as sharp or sharper than a befuddled Christendom that has subsided from the standards of rectitude. But spiritually, blindness has befallen Israel on account of its hardness of unbelief.

Judaism in its pride may deny this, but orthodox Christianity generally accepts this fact, but they forget the blindness is in part. The word "meros" means a part, fraction. Christ came into the parts of Tyre, of Caesarea, and Dalmatia, which means that he came only in the boundaries of those places. The prodigal asked for the part of goods that fell to him Luke 15:12. They gave Christ a piece, part of broiled fish, Luke 24:42. Every soldier got a part of Christ's garment, John 19:32. Ananias brought a certain part, Acts 5:2. We know in part, and prophecy in part I Corinthians 13-9. Christ went into the lower parts of the earth, Ephesians 4:9. Now in all these and similar passages, orthodox theologians grasp the word part real well as meaning a fragment or portion of the whole, a bit. Why then should we not take the word here in the same natural sense? This word in itself clearly forbids that we should ascribe to Israel a blindness that is total and irretrievable. The elect remnant also assures us that Israel's

blindness is not absolute and incurable. In fact, what malady could ever be incurable for Israel's God?

Romans 11:25, Until

This little word achri argues Israel's blindness to be only temporal and not forever. No word could express the partial blindness of Israel better than meros, as we have seen, and no word in Scripture could even describe the temporality of this blindness than this particle achri. Let us look at a few passages where this word is used.

Matthew 24:38, until the day that Noah entered the ark.

Luke 4:13, Satan departed from Christ for a season.

Luke 21:24, Jerusalem shall be trodden under foot until the times of the Gentiles be past.

Acts 1:2, Christ taught until the day He was taken up.

Acts 2:29, David's sepulchre is with us until this day.

Acts 3:21, Christ is in heaven until the times of restitution.

Acts 13:4, Bar-Jesus did not see the sun for a season.

Acts 20:11, Paul preached even till break of day.

Acts 23:1, Paul kept a clear conscience, until this day.

Acts 26:22, I continue unto this day.

Romans 5:13, Until the law sin was.

Romans 8:22, Creation travails in pain together until now.

I Corinthians 4:11, Even unto this present hour.

I Corinthians 11:26, Show the Lord's death till He come.

I Corinthians 15:25, Christ reigns till He has put down all enemies.

II Corinthians 3:14, A veil is on Israel until this day.

Galatians 3:9, Till the seed should come.

Philippians 1:6, Until the day of Jesus Christ.

Revelation 20:3, Satan is bound till the thousand years be finished.

With the exception of perhaps the last passage all orthodox believers accept these infallible statements at their face value in the sense that this particle expresses duration to a certain point, and then it terminates. Why then in the name of sanctified common sense should we disregard this same little word in our text, where it says with unmistakable clarity that there is a terminal point to Israel's blindness. As sure as this is partial, it is also temporal. Its end is just as sure as its beginning, its reality, and its duration. Sin brought it on, but where sin abounds grace doth much more abound. If sin could cause this blindness, can God's great salvation not cure it?

Romans 11:25, The fullness of the Gentiles be come in.

This verse clearly gives the lie to British-Israelism, according to which the British Empire is Ephraim and the United States is Manasseh. If this theory were true, then England must be hardened and blinded for a part and time and then England must be differentiated from the Gentiles. Then the English must be a circumcised nation, must also be a nation in exile and scattered among all other nations. It must then be under the Mosaic law and keep the Sabbath and not Sunday. Then they are Paul's kinsmen after the flesh and should be called Israelites.

If they are called Jews 174 times in the New Testament, they are also called Israel 75 times, hence all discrimination between these two is futile. Then they should speak Hebrew or at least their language should be very similar to this ancient language, which it is not. The Dutch and Scandinavian tongues are far more like Hebrew than the English. According to the prophecy of Balaam Israel was to dwell alone and be not reckoned among the nations, but England does not dwell alone and is most and first of all reckoned among and by the nations. The theory is utterly absurd and breaks down in a thousand-fold ways. Yet many believe it.

The pleroma, fullness of the Gentiles must be carefully distinguished from the times of the Gentiles, which has reference to the time that Israel was set aside as Jezreel, scattered over the earth; Lo-Ruhamah, having-no-mercy, and Lo-Ammi, not my people, the names of Hoseah's children. It is also to be differentiated from the fullness of the times, Galatians 4:4, when God sent forth His Son. Above all it must be carefully separated from the general conversion of the Gentiles, which will come only after and through Israel's conversion. The fullness in the active sense of filling up just as it has been translated in Matthew 9-16; Mark 2:21; 8:20 of the piece of cloth filling up the tear, and the fragments filling up the baskets. The fullness of times of Ephesians 1:10 points to the future. This fullness refers to the present filling up of the mystical Christ from among the Gentiles, to make the new man full, i.e. Christ and His Church. That filling up coming into Christ and into heaven is the end of Israel's blindness and the sign of his salvation.

THE PRE-PRISON EPISTLES OF PAUL

The Pre-prison epistles of Paul are Romans, I and II Corinthians, I and II Thessalonians, Galatians and I Timothy. Under the influence of Bullinger and Welch, many are now thoughtlessly saying that these letters are "all Jewish, nothing but Jewish," to quote their own expression. Fifteen years ago I publicly sailed into a brother who taught this in a Chicago Church, for I have always detested this heresy, and I do so today, though we can love the brethren that hold this unscriptural idea.

I have registered my protest against this in the "Morning Star" more than once and I want to do so once again.

1. Their main ground for this is the saying of Paul in Acts 26:22, "Saying none other things than those which the prophets and Moses did say should come." This word plainly refers to his sayings in the Synagogue, but not to his written ministry which was to the Gentiles and for all ages. Naturally he would not speak anything else in the Synagogue than that Jesus was predicted as the Messiah in Moses and the Prophets.

2. Though Jesus, in His earthly and personal ministry, was a deacon of the Jews, Romans 15:8, nevertheless this Deacon became the Lord of all in resurrection, 14:9, and Paul with his gospel of the uncircumcision became the herald of this Lord of all. As such we find Christ in all these Epistles. Where the twelve ended, Paul began. Where they testified of what they had seen, heard, and touched, Paul could draw upon his many revelations as he clearly does in these Epistles.

3. This weird view with one stroke destroys the idea of a progressive revelation. After all the Prophets, the Gospels, and Acts, there allegedly is nothing in these Epistles of the Apostle of the Gentiles but Moses and the Prophets. "None other things."

4. But where do we find in the Pentateuch and Prophets that a Hebrew of the Hebrews was converted by the Messiah and sent to the Gentiles?

5. Where do we find that "circumcision availeth nothing." Suppose a Jew under Moses had said this. Would he not have been dragged outside the camp and buried under rocks till he were dead? Such a blasphemer would have been killed without mercy.

6. Where do we find in Moses that there is no crisis, no judgment for those who are in a crucified Messiah? Romans 8:1.

7. Where do we find that a man is justified by simple faith apart from all works?

8. Where do we find there that those who are under the law are under the curse, or that we are not under the law but under grace? Romans 6:14.

9. Where does Moses say that nothing can separate us from the love of God which is in the crucified Messiah? Romans 9:39.

10. Where does he say that Jew and Gentile were baptized in one Body? I Corinthians 12:13.

But why carry coal to Newcastle? There is not one single chapter that we find in Moses or the Prophets which certainly gives the lie to their foolish interpretation of "none other things." How strange that those who truly love our Lord and His Word can so blindly and tenaciously follow a certain tenet of some teacher. Let the brethren "recover themselves from this snare of the devil." II Timothy 2:26.

How passing strange that modern believers should call the very letters in which Paul fights Judaism might and main, "nothing but Moses."

IS THE BODY THE BRIDE?

The word for bridegroom, "nymphios," is found six times in Matthew, 9:15, (twice), 25:1,5,6,10; three times in Mark, 2:19 (twice), 20; twice in Luke, 5:34,35; three times in John, 2-9; 3-29 (twice), and once in Revelation 18-23. We may assume that it always refers to our Lord Jesus Christ except in John 2:9 and in Revelation 18-23. He is therefore called the Bridegroom fourteen times.

The feminine of “nymphios" is “nymphe," bride. This word appears eight times in the New Testament. In Matthew 10:34 and Luke 12:53 it is translated "daughter in law" three times. In Revelation 18:23 it refers to the bride in general, perhaps also in John 3:29, while in Revelation 21:2,9, and 22:17 it refers to the heavenly Bride of the celestial Bridegroom.

This little list is telling and clearly shows the following: a) that Christ is the Bridegroom; b) that He will have a bride, and c) that the whole bridal idea is absent from the Epistles. The Body of Christ is never called the Bride, nor the Bride of Christ, nor the Bride of the Lord Jesus, nor the Bride of the Lamb, nor the Bride of the Redeemer, or any such name. Not one of these expressions is found in the Bible, though we find it in our hymnology and in a theology that does not ask, What saith the Lord?

There are mainly four bridal theories, as follows.

1. There are some who maintain that Israel is the bride, and they refer us to Canticles, Hosea, and Psalm 45, but Israel is always regarded as the married wife, who played the harlot, and sits now lonely and forsaken, Hosea 3:3-5.

2. The most general theory is that the Church which is the Body, is the bride. We do not overstate the case when we say that this is the universal and historical view of the Eastern and Western Churches, and also of Fundamentalism, since the Scofield Bible has perpetrated this ancient tradition.

3. A third view is that an elect group from the Body forms the bride. This was generally held by the Roman and Protestant mystics, and in our day it has been strongly advocated by W. B. Godbey, the late leader of the International Holiness People, who have their center in God's Revivalist Bible School in Cincinnati (1944). Godbey was a godly and able man who translated and expounded the whole New Testament for his people. The late Dr. F. E. Marsh also adhered to this opinion as well as many others. However, in this age of grace we may well be a bit suspicious of all the inner circle theories.

4. A fourth theory that has found, and is finding more foothold with many Bible students in our day rejects these three theories and holds that the true believers in Christ from among the people of Israel form the bride. This view was propounded by the Companion Bible of Bullinger and by Dr. Robert A. Hadden, the late President of the Christian Fundamentals League, who compiled seven charts on the question, "Who is the Bride?" Another great Bible teacher who advocated this view was Sir Robert Anderson, called by James M. Gray, the "greatest of all Bible teachers." Those

who know his books will admit that Sir Anderson was an expert in rightly dividing the Scriptures.

C. F. Hogg wrote in the "Witness," "The phrase, The Bride of Christ, is not found in Scripture, and inasmuch as it combines the figures of different writers, it is to be deprecated."

Mr. Wilson Heath, the learned secretary of the English Prophecy Investigation Society, also refuted the first three theories and adhered to the last theory.

Mr. John Rae, with Sir Anderson, who is one of the leading Brethren, was also strongly convinced that the Body is not the Bride, and that the last view alone can stand the test of the Scriptures. Many other able and godly men could be mentioned who have in the last years become convinced that we have no scriptural right to identify the Body and the Bride, but we will not carry coal to Newcastle.

Generally we find that the identification of the Bride and the Body has originated with a lack of discrimination and has proceeded upon the unproved assumption that the city of God of Revelation 21:2,9 is the same as the mystical Body of Christ. Just a bit of sober and unbiased thought could have cured this false assumption for Israel's number twelve is connected nine times with this city.

The city hath twelve gates, V.12.

At the gates were twelve angels, V.12, and angels are always, only connected with Israel.

The twelve tribes of Israel, V.12. The wall has twelve foundations, V.14.

On the foundations are the names of the twelve apostles, V.14.

The magnitude of the city is twelve thousand furlongs, or 1500 miles square, V.16.

The twelve gates were twelve pearls, V.21.

The tree has twelve manner of fruits, V.22:2.

Only a blind traditionalism could tear this away from Israel and transfer it to the mystical Body of Christ. Actually the last book of the Bible does not once refer to this Body of Christ. We can therefore rest assured that the twice mentioned bride of Revelation 21:2,9 is not for one moment to be identified with the Body of which Christ is the Head.

WHAT WAS PAUL'S THORN?

This is one of the many questions that will never die down.

Many have thought that Paul had pangs of conscience, since he had persecuted the saints. Others have thought of satanic attacks in his soul as temptations. The monks, much afflicted this way, thought this. But these and similar explanations can safely be ruled out with the simple remark that his thorn was in the flesh, not in his soul. There was something wrong with his body. Some have thought of something deeply humiliating as a hunchback, or a face that was all scarred and marred by smallpox, or epileptic fits, and so on. As to the last it may safely be said that it is ruled out by the fact that he could travel over land and sea and epilepsy would have incapacitated him for such travel. As to the other two it may safely be said that he who was gladly the offscouring of all for Christ's sake would ignore such a little thing as a disfigured body. He cared not for beauty, art or culture but only for Christ and His Church. His thorn was something in his body and not in his mind or soul. Moreover, even his suffering body was not in any way hindered to undergo the most strenuous toil and travel.

The Church father Tertullian thought it was a problem with headaches. Jerome thought it was "shame, because of his mean appearance," but without giving a history of interpretations, I will state briefly my own conviction on this matter. I believe that his physical malady was some sort of eye trouble, and here follow some of the reasons.

Paul had been dazed and dazzled by the brilliancy of the light at his conversion to such an extent that he was totally blind for three days. Only by a miracle was this blindness removed, and it is possible, if not probable, that some results of this blindness remained with him as a constant reminder of his marvelous conversion and calling.

He always used a secretary to write his letters and this also seems to point to eye trouble. Galatians was the only exception to this. He penned this with his own hand, and in the Greek he tells us at the close that he had written them in large letters, and not as our A.V. has it, which states, "a large letter." These large and clumsy letters point in the same direction.

When we accept this theory, a bright ray of light is thrown on a difficult passage in Acts 23:5, where Paul says "I wist not, brethren, that he was the High Priest." He had called Ananias a whited wall for commanding him to be smitten contrary to the law. The law warned, "Thou shalt not speak evil of the ruler of thy people," and Paul accepted the rebuke of the law with the excuse that he did not know that the High Priest had ordered him to be struck. This excuse would have been invalid for a man with perfect eyesight, for even if the Apostle did not know the High Priest personally, he could have easily recognized him by his insignia and his position in the council. Opthalmia would fully explain this otherwise difficult passage.

The statement in Galatians 4:15, "Ye would have plucked nut your own eyes, and have giver, them to me," also makes it most plausible that his "infirmity of the

flesh" and his "thorn in the flesh," was a severe case of eye trouble. These four facts strongly point in that direction.

At any rate, it is of importance to cling to the idea that it was a malady in the flesh and not an affliction in his spirit as the healing brethren try to make us believe. If it is a sin for a saint to be ill, as they claim, then they cannot escape the conclusion that if Paul lived a life of sin, he then could not have been the example he claimed to be, nor could he truly say at the close of his life, "I have fought the beautiful fight."

WAS PAUL RIGHT IN GOING TO JERUSALEM?

Many expositors, preachers and teachers are harsh on Paul for going up to Jerusalem in his later ministry. They are sure that he was out of the will of the Lord. I am equally sure that Paul was fully in the will of the Lord for the following reasons.

1. He fulfilled the prophecy of Agabus when he went, Acts 21:11.

2. He was bound in the Spirit, Acts 20-22. For this argument it does not make much difference whether this is Paul's human spirit or the Holy Spirit, for if it is his own spirit, then the Spirit of God bound his spirit, seeing he was led in his public ministry by the Spirit of God.

3. Christ sweetly comforted him in Acts 23:11, whereas He dealt harshly with Jonah when out of the way, and this was also true with Peter.

4. Paul sets himself forth as an example in Acts 20:18, and he often does this, but a compromiser and temporizer could not be a fit example for us.

5. He said that he was pure from the blood of all men, but this could not be truly said if he made a moral lapse of self-will and disobedience. Disobedience is rebellion and like the sin of witchcraft, I Samuel 15:23.

6. He said in Acts 20:24 that he finished his course with joy. He started this course on the way to Damascus, he continues it in I Corinthians 9-26 and here he expects to finish it with joy. But it is psychologically impossible that a cowardly rebel can have the joy of the Lord. David, the man after God's heart, lost all the joy of salvation when he sinned.

7. Paul's motives were pure in going to Jerusalem. It was not merely to help the poor saints in Jerusalem. He could help them from anywhere and any faithful man could carry a collection to them. It was to bring the gospel of the grace of God with the righteousness-apart-from-the-law, and thus to become conformed to Christ in all things. He had a burning but holy ambition to know the fellowship of His suffering and to become conformable unto His death. The Jews would cry "away with Him" as they had done with his Lord. They would hate, decry, bind him and in the name of the law deliver him into the hands of the Gentiles, as they had done with his Master before him.

8. They say Paul was at once persecuted in Jerusalem. How is it possible that preachers dare give this as a proof that Paul was out of the way. If that is a proof of rebellion and compromise, then every Prophet, also the Great Prophet, stands condemned. Not to be persecuted is often a proof of compromise, but the reverse is not true.

9. At the end of his life, he states that he had fought a good fight; no man-pleaser could have said this. Paul never made lapses like Peter.

This accusation of Paul rests mainly upon the misunderstood statement of Acts 21:4, "Who said to Paul through the Spirit that he should not go to

Jerusalem." Paul went in spite of this, hence he disobeyed the Spirit; at least so goes the reasoning. This seems to settle the whole matter at once and implies that Paul determinedly crossed the will of the Spirit. For one that knows the original text it is, however, not so easily settled.

The Greek has four negatives; on me, "in no wise," the word Peter used wrongly in Matthew 16:22. Thank God, the Savior used it in Matthew 5:18 and John 6:37.

A little weaker is ouchi, Matthew 4:4; 5:21.

The little negative ou is our "not."

The weakest, the conditional, subjective and relative "not" is me, and that is used here in Acts 21:4. We have it in Matthew 10:5, "Go not into the way of the Gentiles, i.e. not now, but in the next aion, see 28:19. In John 20:17 Christ said "touch Me not," but a week later He asked Thomas to touch Him, 20:27. In Acts 1:4 we read that the disciples should not depart from Jerusalem, but later they did go out of the city, at least some of them. So it was the will of the Spirit that Paul should tarry a week in Tyre, and he did. When those seven days were accomplished he prayerfully left. The disciples of Caesarea said, not "Paul's will be done," but, the "will of the Lord be done." That he sacrificed was because this was still God's will for Israel in those days.

SIGNIFICANT SILENCES IN PAUL'S MINISTRY

Even with scholastic training in the three cultures of Israel, Greece and Rome, Paul never referred to the beauties of art and culture which he had seen in his travels. Christian circles in Germany and Holland boasted of culture, where they should have had all their boast in the cross of Calvary. God Himself is Culturfeindlich, hostile to culture, when it has no room for the Son of His bosom (Deut. 32:15).

Paul prayed much, but he never prayed for material blessings, for he knew too well that these always have a tendency to make Jeshurun fat so that he kicks God in the face.

Paul never thanked God for baptizing as many missionaries and missionary reports generally do, but in I Corinthians 1:14 he did exactly the opposite.

Paul never urged folk to strive to enter something or to seek anything for that matter, for he did not have a do-religion. On the other hand he said, "to him that worketh not."

Paul never referred to one of the thirty-six miracles of Christ but he did boast once in the many miracles he himself had done.

Paul never referred to one of the Parables of Christ nor to the so-called Sermons of Christ.

Paul did not speak of a forgiveness of seventy times seven times but a forgiving "as God in Christ forgave us."

Paul never called Christ the "Son of Man" but the Gospels do eighty times, Acts once, Hebrews once, and Revelation twice.

Paul never calls Christ "priest," but Hebrews does nine times.

Paul never called Christ King of the Jews, nor King of the Church, nor King of heaven, nor King of the world.

Paul never called Christ "Lamb" as we find in Revelation 27 times.

Paul never called Christ "Shepherd," but in John 10 alone He is called the Shepherd ten times.

Paul never called the saints sheep, though he did say that God has given some pastors, i.e., shepherds.

Paul never called Christ the bridegroom nor the Church the bride. In fact the Church is never called the bride of Christ or the bride of the Lord or any similar name.

Paul never boasts that he was an eyewitness of Christ like the other apostles, I Peter 5:1; I John 1:1,2; Hebrews 2:3,4.

This list does not mean to be exhaustive, it is only suggestive of further study and meditation upon the Apostle of the Gentiles. See how often he says in Ephesians 3:1-9, "for you".